

Context Mapping

Map the wider forces surrounding the problem

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Context Mapping visualises the broader system around a problem — stakeholders, trends, constraints, competitors and forces — so the team designs with, rather than against, its environment. It widens the frame from the user to the ecosystem they inhabit.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Rooted in participatory and contextual design (e.g. Sleeswijk Visser et al., 2005); embedded in design foresight toolkits.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Solutions fail when they ignore the surrounding system. Mapping context exposes enablers and barriers that a narrow user focus would miss.

HOW IT IS USED

Place the problem at the centre and map surrounding factors — political, economic, social, technological, stakeholder — noting relationships and pressures that a solution must fit.

WHEN IT IS USED

Define and framing stages, and when planning implementation.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Strategists, service designers and innovation teams.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It connects human-centred design to **systems thinking**, ensuring solutions are viable in their real context, not just the lab.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW



Figure 1. Context Mapping framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

[Trend Analysis](#) *Slibrary 5*

[Vision Cone](#) *Slibrary 6*

[Critical Items Diagram](#) *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Sleeswijk Visser, F. et al. (2005) 'Contextmapping: experiences from practice', *CoDesign*, 1(2), pp. 119–149.

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.